

I.M. Pei

Ieo Ming Pei (b.1917) moved to the United States from China in his teens, studying design at Harvard under Gropius and eventually establishing his own firm in 1955. His modernist designs used expressive geometric forms that incorporated large expanses of glass, and often recall cubist art.

Pei's landmark buildings include the J. F. Kennedy Library in Boston (1965–79), a nine-storey glass and concrete structure; the East Building of the National Gallery of Art in Washington DC (1968–78), comprising overlapping triangular forms that complement the existing neoclassical building; and the monumental reflective-glass Bank of China Tower in Hong Kong (1982–8). He also executed the West Wing and renovation of the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston (1981 and 1986). Perhaps his most famous and controversial commission, however, was a new entrance to the Louvre in Paris (opposite, 1983–89), a bold glass and steel pyramid above a subterranean lobby that provides a spectacular stylistic contrast with the palatial museum itself.

